



ShieldAI

The Virtual CISO Platform

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A full-time CISO costs \$200,000–\$400,000 a year. Nearly half of small businesses have no security budget at all — yet their insurers, customers, and regulators now require a real security program. ShieldAI closes that gap.

ShieldAI is a virtual Chief Information Security Officer (vCISO) platform for small and mid-sized businesses (SMBs). It delivers a complete, continuously-managed security program — risk scoring, written policies, a prioritized roadmap, compliance mapping, awareness training, and executive reporting — at a price a small business can actually afford.

Our strategy is a deliberate wedge-to-platform progression. We begin with a free assessment and an affordable, largely self-serve tier ladder that delivers immediate value and proves the model. As clients grow, we layer human expertise on top: cybersecurity engineers who use ShieldAI to run full, managed CISO programs for a portfolio of clients — with the software (and an AI co-pilot) doing the heavy lifting so a small team can protect a large book of businesses.

ShieldAI is powered by frontier AI for analysis and content generation, but our defensibility does not rest on the AI itself. It rests on four things: a proprietary, deterministic security-scoring engine built on the NIST Cybersecurity Framework that produces explainable, auditor- and insurer-trustworthy results; a human-in-the-loop model in which qualified engineers review and approve work before it reaches the client; the proprietary assessment data and client relationships that compound over time; and direct-to-SMB distribution at a price point the market's best-funded players — Cynomi, Vanta, Drata, Secureframe, Scrut Automation, and Oneleet — have each left structurally uncontested.

The platform has moved well beyond the self-serve wedge: the analyst console is **live in production**, not a mockup, and all 12 supported compliance frameworks are now fully control-mapped, up from 9. Native cross-platform endpoint agents, threat and identity intelligence, vendor risk management, employee training, and a live “vs. Oneleet” competitive comparison shipped alongside it.

Key Highlights

Metric	Detail
Target market	U.S. SMBs with employees, prioritizing regulated and insured segments
Core category	Virtual CISO (vCISO) — ~\$2B+ today, growing 12–15%+ annually
Model	Five-tier ladder — Free \$0 / Starter \$159 / Growth \$349 / Guided \$699 / Managed vCISO \$1,950
Differentiation	Deterministic NIST scoring engine + human-in-the-loop + direct-to-SMB reach nobody else in the category has
Unit economics	\$0.28/client/month AI cost; blended gross margin expanding from ~12% (Y1) to ~74% (Y3)
Stage	Working product live in production; analyst console, monitoring agents, and all 12 compliance frameworks fully built

Metric	Detail
The ask	\$900,000 seed — funds an 8-role Year 1 hiring plan (3 cybersecurity engineers, AI engineer, web developer, IT manager, sales & marketing, HR/admin), each hired to a minimum degree-plus-certification bar with a funded certification and on-the-job training program
Team	Founder-led by Derrick Brooks (CISSP, CISM, Security+, 20+ years, former U.S. Navy Lieutenant Commander); a part-time engineer who helped build the live platform converts full-time on close

Full detail — market sizing, product architecture, competitive profiles, financial projections, the complete hiring plan and certification program, and use of funds — is in the companion Comprehensive Business Plan.